

Wedding ZINGERS

■ By Jhilmil Motihar

Prêt has never been Manav Gangwani's forte. But within 72 hours of showing his bling collection of saris, lehengas and salwar kameezes at the recently concluded Fashion Design Council of India and HDIL Couture Week in Mumbai, the Delhi designer was sold out. With the wedding season upon them, brides-to-be are seeking meetings with couturiers and visiting multi-designer stores to zone in on 'the' outfit. The growing wedding industry is worth over Rs 1 lakh crore and designer wedding-wear forms a sizeable chunk of this cash-rich market. Today's bride wants no less than a designer ghaghra choli. Even if it means spending between Rs 60,000 and Rs 15 lakh. "People are comfortable spending anything between Rs 2.5 and Rs 6 lakh," says Pradeep Hirani, owner of six multi-designer stores, Kimaya and Ayamik.

A substantial portion of the designer wedding-wear buyers budget equitably for the main outfit and others that are worn at pre- and post-wedding functions. And while zardozi, Swarovski and the season's 'it' fabric, velvet, will continue to be favoured this wedding season, merchandisers say customers are consciously moving away from the done-to-death embellishments for other functions. "People are experimenting with stylish blouses and western drapes now," says Chamomile (Delhi and Mumbai) owner Vineet Dhingra, who stocks Gaurav Gupta's wedding collection and adds that Rocky S's sal-

As Couture Week ends and the wedding season begins, eager brides are doling out the cash to get into their customised designer ensembles



VELVET TOUCH

Velvet makes an appearance for the complete outfit as well as on just the borders and sleeves. (Clockwise from top) Designs by Manav Gangwani, JJ Valaya and Varun Bahl.

SHRIYA PATIL SHINDE

